my gaze to Papaji. His face was expressionless, as if nothing had happened. No twitching of muscles—just a plain face. When the process was over, he turned to me and said, ‘See, nothing happened. You’re scared for no reason.’

I agreed to get the injections. I did feel the prick, but it was not as painful as I had imagined. The good part was that after this little success of mine, Papaji treated me to a cassata ice-cream. As we ate spoonfuls, we laughed at my fear of injections, which was now a thing of the past. He had proved to me that it was simple and, therefore, possible. I do not fear injections any more.

* * *

The next morning, Papaji woke me up and took me to his unit’s PT ground, where his entire regiment had lined up in threes for their regular morning PT session. I stood in a corner while Papaji marched to the front. A young officer, dressed in white shorts and a white T-shirt—standard PT rig—received a report from the subedar major and then reported to Papaji, as everyone else stood in attention. ‘Two hundred and thirty-five jawans, fourteen junior commissioned officers (JCOs) and three officers for the morning PT parade, Sir. May I have the permission to march them off?’ To this, Papaji, being the second-in-command of his unit and also the officer-in-charge for training, replied, ‘Please go ahead.’ After the reporting procedure was over, everyone marched off for the morning run. Papaji took me in the opposite direction for the run. He ran ahead of me and I followed; he did as many push-ups as he made me do; he cycled for five kilometres and I followed; he did every exercise that I was supposed to do, and I followed his lead. When we reached home, exhausted, he took me to the storeroom and started to look for something. As I watched in confusion, he fished out an old edition of *Reader’s Digest* from a pile of old newspapers and magazines. With a victorious smile under his thick moustache, he blew the dust off its cover.

‘What is it?’ I asked.